

KANKARIA LAKE FOOD HUB
Ahmedabad

and many cannot imagine a life without their favourite *chaat*, *pakoda* or *chai* vendor. This unorganised sector is not only a source of livelihood and provides an affordable diet to millions, but also represents a rich culinary heritage, attracting many a tourist. According to estimates, some 10 million vendors make up the street vendor market in India, of whom 20 per cent deal in street food. "There's no doubt that street markets are an important source of food, employment and recreation in India," says FSSAI chief executive officer (CEO) G. Kamala Vardhana Rao, "but we haven't managed to invest in them the way it has been done abroad."

That said, amid growing pollution, street food is becoming a source of infections. At Kankaria Lake, the Food and Drug Control Administration, Gujarat, in collaboration with FSSAI and a private firm, had conducted an initial pre-audit to identify gaps. The street food vendors were then trained by the Food Safety Awareness and Training Organisation. A final assessment was done to ensure best practices for garbage disposal, personal hygiene, demarcation of cooking and non-cooking areas, working street lights and pest control.

"The use of plastic is prohibited at the Kankaria Lake food hub," says a senior official of the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation's health department that monitors all food outlets in the city. "We prefer packaged food, with dates of manufacture and expiry clearly mentioned." The department continues to take food samples from these outlets every four months for testing. The area is regularly monitored and vendors sensitised about best practices. "The 'clean street food hub' certificate is renewed biannually, and Kankaria Lake got its latest one just a fortnight ago," adds the official.

The hubs being developed now include Delhi's famed Paranthe Wali Gali in Chandni Chowk. "By improving our food markets," says Rao, "we are not just investing in a healthy future, but also in tourism and employment generation." ■

-with Jumana Shah

"Street markets are an important source of food, employment and recreation in India. But we haven't managed to invest in them the way it has been done abroad"

G. Kamala Vardhana Rao, *CEO, FSSAI*